

The Hand That Rocks The Rig

While DX 10 cards have been here for a while where are all the DX 10 games? Another topic for another time...for now here are the latest—and greatest—graphics cards available today. We'll help you pick the right one too!

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Lets face it... DX 10 isn't going to be any sort of gaming platform—and this, directly from Microsoft's mouth! All DX 10 was supposed to be was a platform for Windows Vista and that gorgeous Aero. It seems DX 10.1 will be the gaming platform, and knowing Microsoft we may see a DX 10.1b or even a DX 11 before game developers switch over from good old DX 9.

We have seen a couple of DX 10 titles but they've been so horribly optimised that even the fastest DX 10 cards slow to a crawl—a slideshow, if you will. Visually, there hasn't been anything radical—but this is natural since game development takes anywhere between two and five years, and simply recoding a DX 9 title for DX 10 doesn't seem to do much in the way of visual realism.

So where does this leave most of today's graphics cards? Well, not out in the cold for sure... simply because all the newest DX 10 cards just happen to make terrific gaming platforms for all DX 9 games. The fact that they were equipped with loads of shader units for effect-intensive DX 10 means they have all the horsepower to deliver blistering frames with all the eye candy enabled on DX 9.

We dug around the market for a while, and unearthed 55 of the most interesting cards for test, after rejecting numerous cards spread across many a variety of GPU cores. We were looking for three categories of chipsets:

- ☑ Those that *performed*, par none.
- ☑ Those that perform well enough, and due to their excellent pricing, make terrific value-for-money purchases.
- ☑ Those chipsets that deliver outstanding value for those of our readers interested in HTPCs, multimedia PCs and general computing boxes.

